



Waipapa  
Taumata Rau  
**University  
of Auckland**

# Teaching and Learning Circles

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*Peer-driven, reflective, and collegial professional development*

Resource Pack

# Teaching and Learning Circles

Teaching and Learning Circles (TLCs) bring together small groups of three to four colleagues who are curious about teaching, and who want a dedicated space to think about it together.

TLCs are designed to be **developmental, not evaluative**. As a circle member, you visit colleagues' classes and they visit yours, not to assess or advise, but to observe with curiosity and reflect on what you see. The focus is always on your own practice: what watching someone else teach makes you notice, question, and want to try.

Great teaching rarely develops in isolation, and TLCs create exactly that opportunity: a structured, collegial space to step into a colleague's classroom, see something new, and bring it back to your own practice.

## Benefits

Taking part in a TLC offers you the chance to:

- Discover new teaching approaches by seeing colleagues in action across disciplines
- Build connections with educators beyond your immediate teaching team
- Deepen your understanding of how students experience learning
- Set aside dedicated time for reflection in a busy semester
- Generate evidence of professional engagement that can support your career goals

**Time commitment:** approximately **5–6 hours** across the semester: around 2–3 hours of class visits and 2–3 hours of reflection and group meetings.

## TLCs and *TeachWell@UoA* Framework

TLCs align directly with the **Reflect** and **Contribute** domains of the *TeachWell@UoA* Framework, and through the observation lenses you choose, your circle also touches on **Teach, Design, and Assess**.

Any reflections or insights you generate through the TLC process are yours to use however you find meaningful in your ADPR, your Academic Career Portfolio, or simply in your own teaching.

## Learning Across Disciplines

TLCs work especially well when members come from different disciplines. When you observe teaching in a field you do not know, something useful happens: you stop following the content and start noticing the teaching itself. How the session opens. How questions are asked. How students are drawn in. How time is structured.

Research on cross-disciplinary observation finds exactly this. Because you are not the disciplinary expert, your attention is freed to focus on practice, and on what it reveals about your own teaching.

That said, circles formed within a single discipline or teaching team are equally valuable. Whatever the context, there is always something worth reflecting on.

## Four Cornerstones

TLCs draw on an established tradition of peer observation practice developed across universities internationally. At the heart of every successful programme are four shared commitments that make collegial observation feel safe, worthwhile, and generative.

### Reciprocity

Every member both observes and is observed. There are no experts and no novices, only peers, each taking turns to open their classroom and to sit in someone else's. This shared trust is what makes the circle work.

### Appreciation

TLC observations are oriented toward noticing and celebrating what works, in your colleagues' classrooms and in your own. The mindset is one of curiosity and generosity, not critique or correction.

### Self-referential reflection

The focus is always on what *you* take away, not on evaluating the person you observed. Every insight is framed around your own teaching: *"This made me think about..."* rather than *"They should have..."*

### Mutual respect

Members enter each other's classrooms with genuine empathy for the teacher, the students, and the context. Different disciplines, class sizes, and teaching situations call for different approaches, and respect means recognising that.

## **Your Circle, Your Choice**

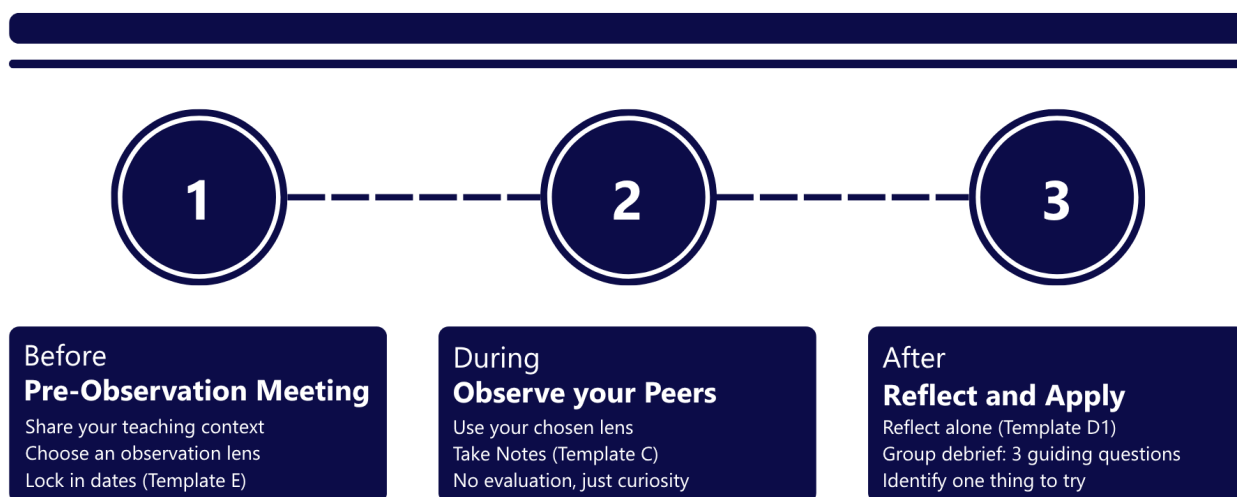
The framework gives you structure and resources, but how your circle uses them is something you decide together. Some circles focus purely on observation and self-reflection, the default TLC approach. Others add informal conversation after visits, sharing what they noticed with the person they observed. Some use the circle as a space for regular, ongoing dialogue about teaching.

If your group wishes, you can also draw on TLC observations to complement the formal peer review process, though this is entirely optional and never a requirement. What matters is that the whole circle agrees on the approach together.

All of these are valid. Your first meeting is the place to decide what suits your group best.

# The TLC Process

Your TLC moves through three stages. The sections that follow walk you through each one in turn.



## Pre-Observation

Stage 1

Once your circle has been formed, your first step is to connect as a group. This can happen however works best: a brief catch-up, a Teams call, or a message thread. The aim is to share your teaching contexts and sort out schedules before observations begin.

### What to organise

- Each member completes **Template A** (Pre-Observation Reflection) privately and shares context about their class with the group (or as much or as little as they choose with the group).
- Each observer selects one or two lenses that resonate with their own teaching questions (see next page).
- Lock in all observation dates together using **Template E** (Circle Scheduling).

**Tip:** Locking in dates early is the single most effective thing your circle can do. Aim to complete all observations within six weeks of your circle forming, before schedules fill up.

A lens gives your observation a starting point. It guides where your attention begins, without limiting what you notice. Before each visit, choose one or two lenses that connect with your own teaching questions. **Template B** (Observation Lenses at a Glance) is a quick reference to bring to every visit. Lenses are aligned to the domains of the TeachWell@UoA Framework.

### Lens 1: Student engagement and learning

*TeachWell: Teach*

- How students respond to questions, tasks, or transitions
- What draws students in or loses their attention
- Whether engagement appears equitable across the class

### Lens 2: Course design in action

*TeachWell: Design*

- How the session's structure and sequencing supports learning
- Whether activities connect clearly to outcomes
- What you might borrow or adapt for your own course

### Lens 3: Inclusive and responsive teaching

*TeachWell: Teach / Te Tiriti*

- How the teacher acknowledges and works with student diversity
- Whether the learning environment feels welcoming to all
- Moments of manaakitanga (hospitality, kindness, and generosity) visible in practice

### Lens 4: Feedback and assessment in practice

*TeachWell: Assess*

- How the teacher provides in-session feedback
- The teacher's responses when students appear uncertain
- What assessment thinking is embedded beyond formal tasks

### Lens 5: Teaching as professional reflection

*TeachWell: Reflect*

- Which teaching decisions are most visible, and what might they reveal?
- What assumptions about learning underpin the session?
- Does anything here challenge or confirm your own teaching approach?

For the host: there is no need to prepare anything special. Teach as you normally would.

For observers: TLC observations are not peer review. The aim is reflection, not critique. Keep your attention on what you notice and what it prompts you to think about in your own teaching.

**Do**

- Observe as a learner, not an evaluator
- Use your chosen lens as a starting point
- Sit with students where possible
- Use **Template C** (Observation Notes) if helpful; brief mental notes are equally fine
- Frame insights around your own teaching: *"This made me think about..."*
- Maintain confidentiality within the circle

**Don't**

- Judge or evaluate teaching performance
- Offer unsolicited feedback during or immediately after the class
- Focus on what you would have done differently
- Share observations outside the circle without explicit agreement from all members

Once all observations are complete, the circle meets to share what each member noticed and what it prompted them to think about for their own teaching. The conversation is structured in three parts. Complete **Template D1** privately beforehand and use **Template D2** to guide the discussion.

**1 What?**  
Descriptive observations from your visits. Factual and specific, no evaluation.  
*"I noticed that..." "I was struck by..."*

**2 So What?**  
What did those observations prompt you to think about in relation to your own teaching?  
*"This made me reflect on my own practice because..."*

**3 Now What?**  
What is each member considering trying or changing as a result of the TLC experience?  
*"One thing I want to try is..." "A question I want to keep exploring is..."*



## Pre-Observation Reflection

A

Complete privately before your circle first connects. Your responses are a starting point for the conversation ahead.

*A prompt for reflection, not a form to submit*

**1 What are you hoping to gain from this TLC?**

*What draws you to it, and what would make it feel worthwhile by the end?*

**2 What are you currently experimenting with or curious about in your teaching?**

*Something new you are trying, a challenge you are navigating, or a question you have been carrying.*

**3 What feels settled and confident in your teaching right now? What feels less so?**

*Honest answers help your circle understand where you are, not where you think you should be.*

**4 Is there anything about your teaching context your circle would find helpful to know?**

*Class size, format, what students have been working on, or anything that helps them understand your situation.*

**5 What, if anything, makes you feel apprehensive about being observed or observing others?**

*Named anxieties tend to shrink. This stays within your circle.*

## Observation Lenses

**B**

Choose one or two lenses before each visit — bring this page with you

*The lens guides where your attention starts. Anything outside it that catches your eye is equally worth noting.*

Lenses are chosen by the **observer**, not the host. Before each visit, choose one or two that connect with your own teaching.

### 1 Student engagement and learning

TeachWell: Teach

- ▷ How students respond to questions, tasks, and transitions
- ▷ What draws students in or loses their attention
- ▷ Whether participation feels equitable across the class

### 2 Course design in action

TeachWell: Design

- ▷ How the session's structure and sequencing supports learning
- ▷ Whether activities connect clearly to learning outcomes
- ▷ What you might borrow or adapt for your own course design

### 3 Inclusive and responsive teaching

TeachWell: Teach / Te Tiriti

- ▷ How the teacher acknowledges and works with student diversity
- ▷ Whether the environment feels welcoming and safe for all
- ▷ Moments of manaakitanga (hospitality, kindness, and generosity) visible in practice

### 4 Feedback and assessment in practice

TeachWell: Assess

- ▷ How the teacher checks and responds to student understanding
- ▷ How misunderstandings or uncertainty are noticed and addressed
- ▷ What assessment thinking is embedded beyond formal tasks

### 5 Teaching as professional reflection

TeachWell: Reflect

- ▷ Which teaching decisions are most visible, and what might they reveal?
- ▷ What assumptions about learning appear to underpin the session?
- ▷ Does anything here challenge or confirm your own teaching approach?

**Before each visit, ask yourself:** "What aspect of my own teaching am I most curious about right now?" Let that be your lens.



## Observation Notes

Print and bring to each visit — these notes are yours and stay within your circle  
Use your chosen lens as a starting point. Note anything that catches your eye.

Observer

Host

Date

My lens

Paper / class

Class format *lecture / tutorial / lab / online / other*

### Category

#### What I notice

*Descriptive: what is happening*

#### What this makes me think about

*Connections to your own teaching, questions it raises, reflections*

#### Introduction

*How does the teacher open the session? What are students doing as class begins?*

#### Voice & presence

*Tone, energy, pace of speech. Where does the teacher stand or move?*

#### Questions & dialogue

*What kinds of questions are asked? How long is the wait time? Do students ask questions too?*

#### Student engagement

*What are students doing — listening, discussing, on laptops? How does the teacher read the room?*

#### Technology & resources

*What tools or materials are used, and how do they support learning?*

#### Inclusive practice

*Who is participating? Does the environment feel welcoming to everyone?*

#### Pacing & structure

*Does the session feel rushed or spacious? Is the structure visible to students?*

#### Conclusion

*How does the class end? Is there a wrap-up, and does it feel complete?*

Something I want to try in my own teaching

What surprised me most

# D1

## Reflect and Apply: Individual

Complete privately before your group debrief — bring it along

*Focus on what you noticed and what it means for your own teaching. These reflections are yours.*

1

### What stood out most across your observations?

*Think about patterns or moments that surprised you, stayed with you, or challenged an assumption you held about teaching.*

2

### What is one thing you noticed in a colleague's class that you want to try or adapt?

*Be specific: what was it, and how might it work in your own context?*

3

### Being back in the role of learner, what did it feel like? What does that prompt you to think about?

*Consider the student experience in your own classes: what might they notice, feel, or need that you hadn't fully considered?*

4

### What do you now see differently about your own teaching?

*This might be a strength you recognised, an assumption that was challenged, or something you want to change.*

One concrete thing I am taking into my teaching next semester:

## Reflect and Apply: Group

# D2

Use this to structure your group debrief — after everyone has completed D1  
*This is not a feedback session on colleagues' teaching. The focus is always on what each member learned for their own practice.*

Date

Location

Present

### 1

**What?** Share descriptive observations from your visits. Factual and specific, no evaluation.

*"I noticed..." "I was struck by..." "Something that caught my attention was..."*

Notes:

### 2

**So What?** What did those observations prompt you to think about in relation to your own teaching?

*"This made me reflect on my own practice because..." "It raised a question for me about..."*

Notes:

### 3

**Now What?** What is each member considering trying or changing? What question do you want to keep exploring?

*"One thing I want to try is..." "A question I want to keep exploring is..."*

Notes:



## Circle Scheduling

Complete when your circle first connects. Lock in all dates in one go.

*Each member records the class they are offering for observation and any context observers should know.*

### Member 1

Name

Email / contact

Course / paper

Date

Time

Location

Context for observers

### Member 2

Name

Email / contact

Course / paper

Date

Time

Location

Context for observers

### Member 3

Name

Email / contact

Course / paper

Date

Time

Location

Context for observers

### Member 4

Name

Email / contact

Course / paper

Date

Time

Location

Context for observers

# Acknowledgements

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This resource pack was developed by Zachary Saunders as part of the Teaching and Learning Circles initiative in the Faculty of Science, University of Auckland. The initiative is led by Dr Shyamli Sindhvani, in collaboration with Dr Jun Seo, who also provided editorial guidance and refinement of the pack.

It adapts the original Teaching and Learning Circles resource developed by the University of Otago and Victoria University of Wellington for Ako Aotearoa, and draws on peer observation programme guides and research from universities internationally. Full sources are listed in the References.

We are grateful to the Faculty of Science for supporting this initiative.

# References

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The design of this resource pack draws on international research on peer observation and reflective practice, established programme guides, and the *TeachWell@UoA* Framework. The sources below informed the principles, the observation lenses, and the developmental, non-evaluative approach that shape every section.

## Programme guides and resources

Berenson, C. (2017). *Teaching Squares: Observe and reflect on teaching and learning*. Taylor Institute for Teaching and Learning, University of Calgary.

Colorado State University. (2024). *Teaching Squares peer observation program facilitation guide*. The Institute for Learning and Teaching (TILT), Colorado State University.

University of Otago & Victoria University of Wellington. (n.d.). *Teaching and Learning Circles* [Resource pack]. Developed by the University of Otago (Division of Humanities and Higher Education Development Centre) and adapted by the Victoria University of Wellington Centre for Academic Development for Ako Aotearoa.

## Peer-reviewed research and reviews

Corcelles-Seuba, M., Sala-Bars, I., Soler, M., & Duran, D. (2024). Impact of reciprocal peer observation on teacher collaboration perceptions. *British Educational Research Journal*, 50(3), 981–1001. <https://doi.org/10.1002/berj.3958>

Cutroni, L., & Paladino, A. (2023). Peer-ing in: A systematic review and framework of peer review of teaching in higher education. *Teaching and Teacher Education*, 133, 104302. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tate.2023.104302>

Esterhazy, R., de Lange, T., Bastiansen, S., & Wittek, A. L. (2021). Moving beyond peer review of teaching: A conceptual framework for collegial faculty development. *Review of Educational Research*, 91(2), 237–271. <https://doi.org/10.3102/0034654321990721>

Kanuka, H., & Sadowski, C. (2020). Reflective peer observations of university teaching: A Canadian case study. *Journal of University Teaching and Learning Practice*, 17(5), Article 11.

Miquel, E., Monguillot, M., Soler, M., & Duran, D. (2024). Reciprocal peer observation: A mechanism to identify professional learning goals. *Education Inquiry*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/20004508.2024.2370116>

O’Keeffe, M., Crehan, M., Munro, M., Logan, A., Farrell, A. M., Clarke, E., Flood, M., Ward, M., Andreeva, T., Van Egeraat, C., Heaney, F., Curran, D., & Clinton, E. (2021). Exploring the role of peer observation of teaching in facilitating cross-institutional professional conversations about teaching and learning. *International Journal for Academic Development*, 26(3), 266–278. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1360144X.2021.1954524>

O’Riordan, F., Buckley, K., & Lincoln, A. (2021). *Peer observation of teaching: Can POT enhance professional development practices within higher education? A literature scoping review*. Zenodo. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.4494444>

## Frameworks and institutional sources

Rogers, T., Wass, R., Timmermans, J., & Golding, C. (2019). *A framework for enhancing teaching culture and practice*. Ako Aotearoa — The National Centre for Tertiary Teaching Excellence.

University of Auckland. (2024). *TeachWell@UoA Framework*. Waipapa Taumata Rau, University of Auckland.



# Contact and Support

Teaching and Learning Circles are designed to be flexible and genuinely supportive. If you have questions at any stage of the semester, we are here to help.

## General Enquiries

For questions about the TLC programme, group formation, scheduling, or resources, please contact:

### TLC Programme Team

Email:

[teachinglearningcircles@auckland.ac.nz](mailto:teachinglearningcircles@auckland.ac.nz)

## Templates and Resources

The templates in this pack are also available digitally via the TLC website:

### TLC Website

[tlcs-uoa.github.io](https://tlcs-uoa.github.io)

## Confidentiality and Care

All Teaching and Learning Circle activities are developmental and non-evaluative. Any concerns raised will be handled respectfully and, where appropriate, confidentially. Support is offered to ensure the experience remains constructive and positive for all participants.

## Ongoing Feedback

We'd love to hear how things are going. A short, anonymous feedback form is open all semester to help the TLC programme grow.

[Share your feedback here](#)

Responses are never linked to individual participants or circles.